



Da Vinci robot assists in a heart surgery

1998**Da Vinci surgical assistant robot**

The first heart bypass operation assisted by a surgical robot was performed at the Leipzig Heart Center in Germany. Dr. Friedrich-Wilhelm Mohr controlled a Da Vinci surgical robot and directed its robot arms, which held a camera and wielded surgical instruments with more accuracy than a human hand could manage.

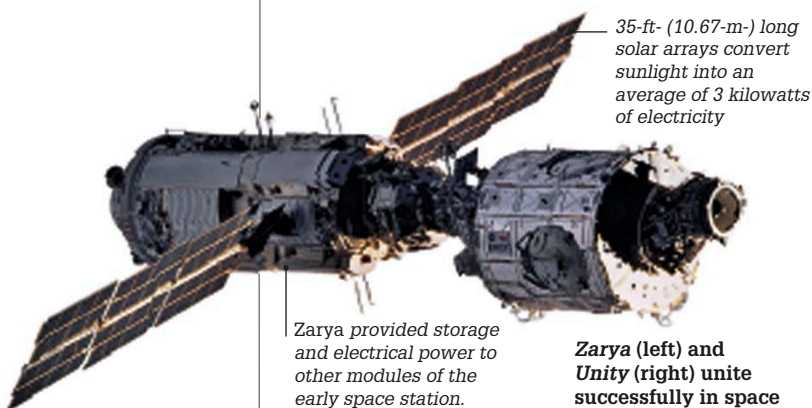
1999**New hormone discovered**

The discovery of a hormone called ghrelin was announced in 1999. Secreted by cells mostly in the stomach and the duodenum, but also elsewhere, ghrelin stimulates appetite and also promotes the storage of fat. More ghrelin is produced before meals and when a person is hungry than after meals when they are full.

2000**1999****Breitling Orbiter 3**

Swiss aviator Bertrand Piccard and British aviator Brian Jones became the first people to circumnavigate Earth in a hot-air balloon. Their nonstop journey in the Breitling Orbiter 3 began in Switzerland and ended 25,361 miles (40,814 km) later when they landed in Egypt after 19 days and 21 hours. The 180-ft- (55-m-) tall hot-air envelope was maintained by six gas burners and also contained a cell filled with helium for extra lift.

Breitling Orbiter 3 over the Alps, 1999



35-ft- (10.67-m-) long solar arrays convert sunlight into an average of 3 kilowatts of electricity

Zarya provided storage and electrical power to other modules of the early space station.

Zarya (left) and Unity (right) unite successfully in space

1998**International Space Station is born**

The first module of the International Space Station (ISS), a 21-ton- (19-metric ton-) functional cargo block (FCB) called *Zarya*, was ferried into space on board a Russian Proton-K rocket. In the same year, the first US module, *Unity*, was carried into space on board a space shuttle, before docking with *Zarya*.



In 1997, Russian world chess champion Garry Kasparov lost to IBM's Deep Blue computer over a six-game contest.